

interruptions of the Energizer bunny. The marketer anticipated your familiarity with convention (ugh, another boring commercial) and shocked the audience by interrupting that boredom with a pink rabbit. AdAge.com recognized these commercials as one of the top 100 campaigns of all time.

Another mocker of convention is the Geico Insurance Company, which took typical situations and interjected the scenes with a surprise punch line: “I’ve got great news! I just saved a bunch of money on my car insurance.” Conventional scenarios were shattered with the narrative, “I’ve got great news,” which created unconvention. Another Geico spot mocked convention when it appeared you were watching a promo for a new reality TV series called “Tiny House.” The promo featured a newlywed couple who supposedly move into a midget-sized apartment for one full year and endure cramped quarters and rising marital tensions. You see the couple hitting their heads on low ceilings and struggling for a good night’s sleep in a tiny bed. But wait a second, this expected convention of reality is nothing but a ruse that will shatter into unconvention when an announcer voices: “The drama will be real, but it won’t save you any money on car insurance.”

If you get someone’s attention, half the battle is won. The other half is letting selfishness take over your audience and tailor your messages to self-interest. In other words, the good old “What’s in it for me?” How about saving 15% or more on your car insurance?

WHAT’S IN IT FOR ME?

It’s ironic: To succeed a Fastlane we must forsake selfishness yet satisfy the selfishness of others. Did I say this would be a nice cozy stroll down the beach?

The first human behavior you can count on is selfishness. People want what they want. People don’t care about you, your business, your product or your dreams; they want to help themselves and their family. It’s human nature. Therefore, our marketing messages must focus on benefits, not features. People need to be told exactly what’s in it for them. How will your product or service help them? What’s the benefit? In marketing speak, it’s called the “What’s In It For Me?” (WIIFM) principle.

My customers were small-business owners and yet I served millions of consumers, too. This intermediary relationship allowed me to study the behavior of both consumers and producers in a powerful, accelerated fashion. I learned things in weeks that would take educators months to ascertain. I noticed that small-business owners fall into their own selfish trap and love singing the praises of their company. They sell features, not realizing that people rent convenience and events, not limousines.

As consumers, we buy things to solve needs. We engage in transactions to fill voids. You don’t buy a drill; you buy a hole. You don’t buy a dress; you buy an image. You don’t buy a Toyota; you buy reliability. You don’t buy a vacation; you